INTRODUCTION TO 30TH ANNIVERSARY EDITION

It is sobering to realize that I have lived nearly half my life with *The Selfish Gene*—for better, for worse. Over the years, as each of my seven subsequent books has appeared, publishers have sent me on tour to promote it. Audiences respond to the new book, whichever one it is, with gratifying enthusiasm, applaud politely and ask intelligent questions. Then they line up to buy, and have me sign … *The Selfish Gene*. That is a bit of an exaggeration. Some of them do buy the new book and, for the rest, my wife consoles me by arguing that people who newly discover an author will naturally tend to go back to his first book: having read *The Selfish Gene*, surely they'll work their way through to the latest and (to its fond parent) favourite baby?

I would mind more if I could claim that *The Selfish Gene* had become severely outmoded and superseded. Unfortunately (from one point of view) I cannot. Details have changed and factual examples burgeoned mightily. But, with an exception that I shall discuss in a moment, there is little in the book that I would rush to take back now, or apologize for. Arthur Cain, late Professor of Zoology at Liverpool and one of my inspiring tutors at Oxford in the sixties, described *The Selfish Gene* in 1976 as a 'young man's book'. He was deliberately quoting a commentator on A.J. Ayer's *Language Truth and Logic*. I was flattered by the comparison, although I knew that Ayer had recanted much of his first book and I could hardly miss Cain's pointed implication that I should, in the fullness of time, do the same.

Let me begin with some second thoughts about the title. In 1975, through the mediation of my friend Desmond Morris I showed the partially completed book to Tom Maschler, doyen of London publishers, and we discussed it in his room at Jonathan Cape. He liked the book but not the title. 'Selfish', he said, was a 'down word'. Why not call it *The*